PRESS NOTE

14 January 2023

Assam Agar Traders and Manufacturers Association expresses its extreme gratitude and happiness over notification of Assam Wood Based Industries (Promotion and Development) Rules 2022 on 12th January 2023.

AATMA takes this opportunity to profusely thank Dr Himanta Biswa Sarma, Hon'ble Chief Minister of Assam, for his visionary leadership and for taking this great initiative of bringing back the glory to Agar Wood Based Industries.

There are about 1000 Agar Wood Based Industries in Assam, which are predominantly located in Hojai, Golaghat, Sibasagar etc. These industrial units suffered set back due to imposition of various legal restrictions for operation of Agar Wood Based Industries. AATMA expresses its pleasure over repealing of existing Assam Wood Based Industries (Establishment and Regulation) Rules 2000 and notifying Assam Wood Based Industries (Promotion and Development) Rules 2022.

Major features of the Assam Wood Based Industries (Promotion and Development) Rules 2022 such as categorizing Agar Wood Based Industries as Secondary Wood Based Industries and liberating the trade from license regime and associated restrictions and simplifying the procedures for registration of the Agar Wood Based Industries by Registration Committees at the level of Conservator of Forests concerned will immensely benefit the Agar wood industry and provide much needed boost. The rules are made fully CITES compliant and paved way for revival of Agar Wood Industries and the import and re-export as well as export of domestic agar wood products.

With the notification of these rules, the Agar Wood Based Industries in Assam can function from the present locations after obtaining registration under the new rules, which is valid for five (5) years. The categorization of Agar Wood Based Industries into Micro, Small, Medium and Large units based on the aggregate capacity of each unit. This provides necessary impetus for small traders to conduct the trade in an affordable manner.

AATMA firmly believes that all these provisions in new rules will radically transform the Agar Wood Trade in to a vibrant industry.

AATMA duly recognises the recent notification of Assam Trees Outside Forest (Sustainable Management) Rules 2022. Assam has huge population of Agar trees growing on non-forest lands by private farmers. These rules promote and facilitate the creation of Agar tree plantations on non-forest lands, thereby, making raw material available for Agar Wood Based Industries by simplifying procedures for registration of Agar tree plantations and felling and transportation of harvested material from various parts of the State to Agar Wood Based Industries.

Both the above said rules operate on complete and interactive end-to-end online platform for traders/planters which provide complete transparency and timely permissions by reducing human interface.

AATMA also recognizes and places its appreciation on record for the contribution of Assam Forest Department, under the leadership of Sjt Chandra Mohan Patowary, Hon'ble Minister Forests etc,

Government of Assam, behind notification of the above said two rules.

Assam Wood Based Industries (Promotion and Development) Rules 2022 and Assam Trees Outside Forest (Sustainable Management) Rules 2022 complement and supplement each other and provide favourable ecosystem for complete revival and growth of Agar trade in the State of Assam, benefit the small and marginal farmers, agar wood distillation industry and other traders while providing employment to lakhs of skilled workers who are directly or indirectly engaged in Agar trade.

While assuring that AATMA will sincerely and committedly take this initiative forward to achieve the desired objective, we heartily welcome this new era in the history of Agar Wood trade.